

STAFF PARTICIPATION IN POLITICAL ACTIVITIES

The Loudoun County School Board recognizes that all employees have the right to engage in political activity. An employee's participation in such political activities must not adversely affect the employee's job performance and be in compliance with all laws, rules and regulations. No School Board resources shall be used by employees for non-LCPS business including, but not limited to, use of the email system, vehicles, buildings, copying machines or other assets.

A. Guidelines. "Employees", as used in this policy, refers to individuals employed by the School Board but who are not School Board members. No employee shall engage in the following activities:

1. Use their position within the school division to further a political cause, campaign, or support of any issue on any referendum matter during work hours.
2. Distribute campaign materials to any students and/or staff during school hours, except when such distribution is relevant to the curriculum and current candidates for the same office are treated equitably in accordance with Section B of this policy.
3. Suggest in any official work capacity that the school division or any component of it supports or opposes a candidate for election to any office or any particular political party.
4. Discuss internal confidential affairs in a public forum.

B. Instructional Practices.

1. This policy shall not be construed to prohibit the discussion or use of political or issue-oriented materials as part of classroom discussions or projects or to prohibit the delivery of informational materials. If debates or other activities consistent with the curriculum are held, all candidates for a particular office must be offered the opportunity of comparable time to speak.

2. These guidelines are not intended to limit the rights of school division employees to support or oppose any political candidate or party on their own time or to prevent officeholders from performing duties associated with their offices. They are intended to minimize distractions from instruction, to assure that no public funds and/or resources are used to support any candidate for public office, and to assure that the

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public is not given the impression that the school division supports or opposes any political candidate or party.

C. Personal Political Activities.

1. School division employees who engage in political activities on their own time must make it clear that their views and actions represent their individual positions and do not represent the views of the school division.

2. Employees planning to act as a campaign manager or seek, accept an appointment or be elected to public office must give prior notice of their intentions to the Chief Human Resources Officer or designee. The Chief Human Resources Officer or designee will review with the employee the school system's continuing requirements to avoid conflicts of interest and to maintain satisfactory attendance, effort, and performance standards.

D. Absences.

1. Time spent working on political activities normally should be outside of the employee's working hours and, in such circumstances, will not be considered hours worked for pay purposes. Voluntary employee participation in political activities that involves an extended period of time away from the job should be handled in accordance with the provisions contained in the Leave without Pay, Policy and Regulation §7-58.

2. Time spent in community affairs at the school system's request or under its direction or control, will be considered hours worked for pay purposes in accordance with the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA). Also, in these circumstances, the school system will reimburse employees any reasonable expenses, if approved in advance.

3. Employees who accept appointment to public office will be permitted time away from the job in accordance with Policies and Regulation §7710, Annual Leave; §7722, Leave without Pay; and §7714, Personnel Leave.

4. Employees who campaign, seek and are elected to public office will be permitted time away from the job in accordance with Policies and Regulations §7710, Annual Leave; §7722, Leave without Pay; and §7714, Personnel Leave.

5. Under this policy an employee may be permitted leave of absence without pay beyond which is provided in §7722 upon the recommendation of the Superintendent and approval of the School Board.

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[Former Policy §7-61]

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Legal Refs: Code of Virginia, 1950, as amended, §§ [22.1-70](#), [22.1-78](#), [22.1-79](#)